Q+A

THE PAST COMES FIRST

Last week, **Geetanjali Shree's** *novel* Tomb of Sand (Ret-Samadhi *in the original Hindi; translated into English by Daisy Rockwell) became the first Hindi novel to win the International Booker Prize. We caught up with the 64-year-old Delhi-based writer shortly after the announcement.*



Photo by SHANE ANTHONY SINCLAIR/GETTY IMAGES

Q. You've written books in both Hindi and English. Was this bilingual output always part of the plan or was it just circumstance? Did you ever feel the temptation to translate your own Hindi work into English?
My creative writing is exclusively in Hindi. However, my doctoral dissertation–subsequently published as *Between Two Worlds: An Intellectual Biography of Premchand*–and periodic discursive writings have been in English. Rather than translate my work in English, I'd rather write something new in Hindi.

Q. *Tomb of Sand* shows us how the distant past continues to shape one's daily life, even after 50-60 years. How does one cultivate a healthy, functional relationship with history?
That past in *Tomb of Sand* goes back much longer than mere 50-60 years. That said, the past, in general, functions within and upon us in a variety of ways. Of these ways, we're often not even conscious. However, to the extent we realise the importance of forging a healthy relationship with the past, our concern must be to understand what–good and bad, noble and mean–happened in the past so as to further the good and the noble, and spurn the bad and the mean.

Q. To a European or an American or even an Indian reader unfamiliar with Hindi literature, what books-in-translation would you recommend as a 'starter kit'?
One may begin with modern classics, such as *Godan*, *Tamas*, *Raag Darbari*, *Adha Gaon*, *Maila Aanchal*, *Dil-o-Danish* and *Zindaginama*.

Q. What are you working on right now, and after this victory can we expect more English translations of your previous works (especially your short stories) soon?
A word like 'victory' has no place here. I have completed a novel. I wish to steal away at the earliest and prepare its press copy, not speculate about future translations.

–with Aditya Mani Jha